JOURNAL OF ADULT THEOLOGICAL EDUCATION, Vol. 10 No. 1, May, 2013, 64–77

Theological Epistemology and Non-Foundational Theological Education

ANDRÉ VAN OUDTSHOORN

Academic Dean, Perth Bible College, 1 College Court, Karrinyup WA 6018 Australia

Theological education can no longer operate according to a modernistic epistemology if it is to equip students to minister in a postmodern world. This article explores the possibility of developing a theological epistemology which does not blindly reflect the presuppositions of either modernism or postmodernism. It is argued that the theological notions of faith, hope and love provide a unique approach to truth that frees theological epistemology from fideism, fundamentalism and triumphalism. Faith renders theological theories vulnerable to being challenged by experiences of lived-through reality and alternative interpretations of that reality, while hope sets truth within the context of critical transformational actions based on relational commitments marked by love. A meta-theoretical model for theological education is constructed to indicate how this epistemological approach may be realized in educational praxis.

KEYWORDS theological education, epistemology, critical realism, theological metatheory

Introduction

Kodak Film Company, the undisputed world leader in all things photographic only a few decades ago, has recently filed for bankruptcy.[1] The reason given is that they did not adapt in time to the reality of the new digital world. The obvious lesson from this is that even billion-dollar companies, certain of their place and power in the world, remain so only as long as the world they inhabit remains the same. Theological education, today, I believe, faces the same dilemma as the Kodak

[1] According to the *West Australian* (23 January 2012, p. 21) up to the late 1970s Kodak supplied more than 90% of all camera film in the United States.

© W. S. Maney & Son Ltd. 2013

DOI 10.1179/1740714113Z.0000000005

company: a world that is changing around us so quickly that theological training may equip students for ministry in a world that no longer exists.[2] Janet Dale bemoans the anti-intellectual stance that characterizes many (evangelical) seminaries and which ill-equips students to deal with problems in life which cannot always be reduced to simple black and white categories—so-called 'ill-structured problems'. True reflective thinking, she argues, occurs 'when adults think about problems that involve real complexity and uncertainty', and then adds, 'epistemic assumptions affect how individuals assess and resolve these ambiguous, ill-structured issues' (2005, 1). King and Kitchener concur: 'Making interpretive judgements about ill-structured problems involves constructing beliefs, a task that requires people to wrestle with questions about the limits, certainty, and criteria for knowing, factors that comprise "epistemic cognition"' (Hofer, 2004, 38).

In this article I argue that the Bible develops its own distinct epistemology through the categories of faith, hope and love. These three combine to represent an approach to reality and knowledge that (a) frees truth from universal claims and triumphalism by (b) setting it within communal and ethical contexts that (c) allows for the future reconstruction of truth as well as (d) the transformation of resistant reality in the light of God's action for, with and within this reality. The argument is substantiated, first, by showing that faith, by definition, precludes epistemological certainty: while it confesses certain truths as final truths, those truths are always open to be doubted in the light of the way things are (ontology). The way faith operates in the biblical text thus reaches beyond the confines of faith itself to engage with what 'is' in such a way that this reality may contradict faith's claims and interpretation of it. In this way a theological understanding of faith overcomes the triumphalism and relativism of both foundationalism and fideism without giving up on either the interpretive or realist dimensions of knowledge. Second, by linking knowledge to hope, truth is firmly set in the context of the future. For the Bible, true knowledge is not only linked to what 'is' but also to what 'will be'. Knowledge is thus not only descriptive but transformational. In as much as hope in the Bible is intertwined with faith, it purports to have adequate reasons to expect such transformation. Hope thus does not negate the possibility of constructing truth in and for the present, even though such truth may only be provisional and anticipatory in the light of possible future interpretations of reality. Third, this article demonstrates that the concept of 'love', as it is used in the Bible, always points to an ethical dimension in knowledge. Truth is not only what 'is' and 'will be' but also what 'ought to be' in the here and now. Love also implies a personal engagement in the construction of truth, both on an individual level and with others, so that our epistemological interpretations and truth claims also necessarily take on a value dimension within a community context. Truth is, thereby, qualified by the use to which it is put, and thus becomes an operational rather than a purely descriptive concept. To think and know well is, in the final instance, to love well.

[2] Moltmann (2001, ch. 1) already refers to the identity relevance dilemma which faces the church. The church can become so relevant that it loses that which makes it unique and different, or become so different that it has nothing more to communicate to the world.

To place the argument in context, the article will first give a very brief overview of the demise of foundationalism and the resurgence of fideism as a religious language game. Following this, the article will consider the epistemological contributions of faith, hope and love in developing an epistemological meta-theory for theological education before setting up a model of how this approach may be practically implemented in the practice of theological education.

The Demise of Foundationalism

Postmodernism represents a cataclysmic shift in epistemological thinking on what it means to 'know' and how beliefs may be justified. Against the metaphor of a foundation on which certain knowledge can be built, postmodernism would more likely refer to a 'web of beliefs' within which specific beliefs need to cohere (Quine and Ullian, 1978). According to van Huyssteen (1997, 75) postmodern epistemology faces 'the trilemma of trying to keep together in a meaningful whole, a sense of continuity and tradition, a respect for and celebration of pluralism, and a resistance to any form of authoritarian (also epistemological) domination'.

The question must be asked what does it mean to do theology in a postmodern context? The foundational assumptions underlying theology's claims to special and general revelation providing pathways towards theological certainty now face the same epistemological criticism that has been levelled against modernism (Erickson, 1998, 83). Kirk and Vanhoozer (1999, 3) argue that theological training has to face up to this 'epistemological predicament' if it wants to equip students to remain effective in fulfilling the church's mission to the world in which theological fundamentalism is perceived as an existential threat rather than a place of certainty and security.

The temptation is for theology to embrace the possibility that postmodernism offers a set of assumptions under the rubric of faith, and to use this to isolate itself from questioning by insisting, with Wittgenstein, that any religion's own foundational assumptions should be taken seriously as the ground for its internal logic and rules: 'the meanings of religious utterances are relative to different language games' (Martin, 1992, 258). Epistemologically this results in fideism: assumptions posited by faith become the means to justify truth claims without external questioning. For Wittgenstein truth can never be separated from language as a symbolic form of existence by which *that which is*, is interpreted and, thereby, recreated as *that which is, as it is for us and me.*

The Reality of Language

According to Geertz (1973, 91-94) a symbolic world is a socially constructed set of shared meanings that form an ultimate definition and explanation of what 'is'. It is thus the presuppositions or set of assumptions that we bring to any situation to help us make sense of it. Niebuhr suggests that our actions are responses to the actions of others and that we decide which responses to make in the light of the interpretive community to which we belong. 'Personal responsibility implies the continuity of a self with a relatively consistent scheme of interpretations of

what it is reacting to' (1999, 65). The question needs to be asked if there is a further reality other than the humanly constructed interpretive reality to which theological truth can refer?

The Reality of Faith

While it seems that the Bible does set humanity apart as co-creators of reality through language, it does not give it the place of creator. Humanity does not create the animals but only names them.

> By describing man as 'respondable' we delimit him from the outset in his maturity and autonomy. The first word does not come from him. He is made man by an initiative from outside and from above. His creativity is based on re-creativity. God addresses the human and calls her away from any definition of herself and her world as an unchangeable given (Berkhof and Woudstra, 2002, 187).

Without being grounded in another form of reality within which we are embodied through our own physical existence there are no constraints to the possible worlds that we can create and occupy. Reality, however, does constrain us; the world that we have to live in is, and remains, something different from idealism, fiction and fantasy (Norris, 2006, 79). The ontological 'is' of our embodied existence in lived-through reality remains resistant to our language-based wishes or interpretations. As the early Putman (1979, 24) contended: 'We don't just have a "thing theory"—that is, a vast system of hypotheses, everyone which entails the existence of material things—but also a thing language, that is a way of talking which constantly presupposes the existence of material things.'[3] The Bible pictures humanity as more than a passive, transient, synchronic element within the contextual relational structure of language, but pictures us instead as being physically anchored to a resistant, incomplete or broken reality. Faith, as it operates in the biblical narrative, both acknowledges this reality and calls for it to be challenged and transformed in line with its own interpretation of it.

Biblical faith can be defined as knowledge that engages with a non-compliant reality in such a way that it becomes vulnerable to doubt engendered through this engagement. Faith thus constructs truth that constantly must maintain and restore itself within a reality that actively militates against it, and from which it cannot escape (Heschel, 1965, 104). While fideism allows believers to retreat into certainty and so escape from outside criticism, faith incorporates contradictory experiences of reality which casts doubt on its own definition of what 'is'. Faith has some explanatory power for that which 'is not' according to its confessions or theological interpretations of reality; such explanations are, however, not exhaustive. The 'is not' cannot be explained away with reference to propositional certainties or alternative theoretical interpretations, but instead needs to be overcome through historical events which transform that which 'is not' to the 'is'

[3] Putnam later changed his mind and moved towards a more non-realist position. The intention of this quote is not to advocate another form of material foundationalism, but to admit that language cannot be completely separated from material reality.

that faith confesses. Knowledge grounded on faith is thus 'event' and operates as part of a transformational historical narrative.

Theissen (1979, 33-34) believes that religious experience presents the key that allows theology to contribute to the epistemological debate. He argues that God relates to the whole of reality and that humans seeking to find meaning against the background of possible absurdity react positively to that which can create resonance as 'intimations of a central reality that determines and conditions everything' (van Huyssteen, 1997, 211). It is unclear how an epistemological grounding on direct human religious experience can escape replicating Schleiermacher's anthropocentricity in the formation of theological knowledge.[4] Christian faith is not based on any direct experience of the transcendent within that which exists but, instead, reflects both the lack of any direct experience of God within the given order of things and the belief that certain public events reflect the historical intervention by God in this broken reality, culminating in the Christ event.[5] This final revelatory event maintains reality as it 'is' by leaving everything outside of Christ directly unaffected, while claiming that in Him everything has been made new resulting in a dual, paradoxical definition of reality in which faith both maintains the old reality and the new reality in tension with each other and also allows them to clash. It is exactly in allowing this clash that faith knowledge distinguishes itself from the definition of knowledge as absolute and certain.[6]

Faith knowledge calls for rational *assensus*, or agreement with its interpretation of reality.[7] This *assensus* implies a commitment to the presuppositions underlying the theological interpretation of reality, and requires intelligible reasons to explain its 'fit' to a given reality and render that which is to be believed probable. Faith, furthermore, calls the believer to *fiducia*, or trust. *Fiducia* implies an experiential, and to some extent an experimental, engagement with this reality to transform existence according to faith's interpretation of that which 'is'.

The work of the Spirit is to guide believers in their interpretation of reality by focusing them on Christ and the new reality created in Him (Balthasar, 2005, 87).[8] Without this interpretive focus on the new reality in Christ, the presence of the Spirit may result in claims of direct religious experiences of God, binding theological truth once more to epistemological subjectivity and fideistic certainty.[9]

[4] While Schleiermacher is often depicted in grounding theological knowledge on feeling, he intended to convey more than an emotion so that it would be more accurate to describe him referring to gaining theological knowledge at the core of one's being.

[5] The work of the Spirit is understood to be linked to the objective reality in Christ. While the Spirit engages us as individuals, it challenges our interpretations of reality in the light of the Christ-event.

[6] This position differs from Hegel's thesis which links knowledge of God to the providential unfolding of events in history. For Hegel, history reveals God's active reason and true knowledge of God is 'to advance to the intellectual comprehension of what was presented in the first place to feeling and imagination' (2010, 15). God's active interventions, however, contra Hegel, do not progressively overcome the antithesis of reality; the antithesis remains within reality, although its power is challenged by the alternative interpretation of reality developed by faith in response to God's salvific and revelatory events.

[7] Augustine defined believing as thinking with assent; see Schaff, 2007, Book 1 chapter 5.

[8] 'There is no greater emphasis on this in Paul's doctrine of the Spirit; what is essential for him is the Spirit's function of interpreting the revelation in Christ. This takes place in the explanatory word of prophecy but, even more, in the whole of existence' (Balthasar, 2005, 89).

[9] Paul does mention a subjective religious experience in which he was transported into the third heaven (2 Cor. 12:2) but then minimizes its significance in favour of the hardships he suffered in this world as a servant of God (2 Cor. 12:3-10).

Faith, in its epistemological acknowledgement of the 'not yet', calls for critical evaluation of all claims to religious knowledge by the community of faith, harbouring a healthy suspicion of any claims to final certainty and the triumphalism that accompanies such claims. In the context of faith, even the church's confessions are considered as nothing more than fallible interpretations of the biblical text and reality. While the confessions are deemed to have withstood the test of time, they are not granted immunity from being challenged afresh in the light of new evidence. In this revisability of its beliefs theological knowledge is analogous to science which claims an authoritative interpretation of reality but which is also revisable in the light of data that does not fully fit the explanations provided.

Epistemological Characteristics of Faith Informing Theological Education

The epistemological characteristics of faith-informed knowledge can provide a framework for students to existentially reflect on the way they interpret, and engage with, reality from the perspective of faith. To enable such reflection students may be exposed to a range of different tasks across the curriculum that require faith. The types of tasks and contexts to which students are exposed will, of course, differ across different theological fields, but no theological subject is immune from the requirement of faith to expose students to the tension between the Christ-event informed interpretation of reality, the brokenness of the world in which they find themselves, and faith actions taken within this tension. It is only by doing so that students will become equipped to operate within faith-informed epistemology.

Educationally, a theological epistemology characterized by faith should result in a mode of thinking which is:

- *christological and historical*: focused on the new reality realized in, and through, Christ within history. Students' presuppositions about reality are tested by the alternative christological interpretation of reality as witnessed to in the biblical canon and church history.
- *realist and referential*: operating within an objective and objectifiable reality outside of and apart from the subject, within which the subject is embedded (the subject's *lived-through reality*), and to which the believers' secondary inter-subjective interpretive theological constructs of reality refer. This lived-through reality operates as a radical constraint which may resist the new reality in Christ.
- *certain and vulnerable*: a firmly held interpretation of reality that challenges 'what is' and yet remains vulnerable to doubt in the light of believers' continuing participation in lived-through reality as well as a range of contesting alternative interpretations of reality which resists the transformation of faith.
- *critical and questionable*: thinking which is open to test and evaluate claims to truth against other claims and have its own truth claims be tested and evaluated in the same way.
- *complex and simple*: thinking and operating within the tension of multiple interpretations and seeking to find an integrated construct of reality;

- *risky and hopeful*: moving towards realizing an alternative future despite the risk of failure and embarrassment.

It is important to note that a faith-informed epistemology implies hope—the second major dimension of the theological epistemology advocated in this article.

Knowing as Hope

Hope as a dimension of a theological epistemology affects the individual in his or her orientation towards the world. This may be linked to Husserl's notion of *intentionality* as the way in which the individual endeavours to construct meaning within the world, or to construct a meaningful world to occupy.[10] Believers, through the Spirit's presence, are able to reconstruct their present reality to reflect more of how it should be in the light of what it has been made to be in Christ. Hope reflects the dynamic temporal structure of reality which renders that which 'is' relative to that which 'is yet to be' and thus places the knowing subject within an open, pliable reality with the vision of its possible reconstruction. Knowledge grounded on hope can never rest with 'what is'. It is subversive, expecting existing realities to be transformed in the light of the eschatological vision of the coming Kingdom of God. It constructs its criticism from what will be and therefore should be. Current interpretive structures of reality, including those fossilized into cultural and ideological pillars, must be deconstructed and severed from their historical roots through hope, to be reconstructed in the hope of God's future for the whole world. Epistemology marked by hope thus takes on a cosmic-universal dimension.

Biblical hope is not only universal but also directed towards the individual. Knowledge, which defines individuals in terms of their future rather than their present or past, must, necessarily, impact the way theology knowledge operates. Humanity as a new creation in Christ calls for a unique perspective on, and methodology for, dealing with people and their problems. An epistemology marked by hope provides the church with a positive and liberating framework to engage with individuals, and their problems, both in the church and in the world.

Epistemological Characteristics of Hope within Theological Education

Educationally a theological epistemology characterized by hope develops a mode of thinking which is:

- *revisable and humble*: showing a willingness to have its truth claims tested and to reconstruct them in the light of new insights gained from the Spirit's ongoing re-interpretive work in, with and through his people in this broken reality;
- *intentional and eschatological*: focused on finding meaning within this world, yet seeking final integration beyond that which is on the basis of the promise of God of the coming Kingdom;

[10] Intentionality is used by Husserl first of all as the simple act of consciousness of objects in the world and of standing in a relationship to such objects as conceived in a particular way (Smith and McIntyre, 1982, XIII & 14). It is from this relationship that meaning is constructed.

- *universal and individual*: focused on reality as an integrated whole within which the knowing subject fits as a small, limited relational element with only momentary temporal significance. Hope also enlists the knowing subject to participate in the transformation of the immediate context in line with the *eschaton* and thereby giving both the individual and the act of transformation eternal and universal significance;
- *subversive and liberating*: undermining given existence by focusing on the Kingdom of God as an alternative liberating reality which seeks to break in from the future. The presence of the Spirit as a first-fruit of the coming Kingdom critically questions and destabilizes existing structures and calls the church towards actions which seeks to realize how things ought to be against the way things are.

Knowing as Love

Linda Zagzebski notes in her book's introduction that 'love is not usually discussed in a book of epistemology' (Zagzebski 2009, 1). The Jewish theologian Martin Buber has entitled one of his books *Eclipse of God* (1988). He designates the modern world as an *I-It* world, the world of 'dead and lifeless things'; a measurable objectified reality which can be manipulated to conform to our will; a concept of reality that does not acknowledge that our world is filled with inter-personal relationships. He goes further to show that people create an *I-Me* world in which the individual reigns supreme within this *I-It* construction of reality. Against this Buber poses his famous *I-Thou* dictum in which the Other (both God and other humans) finds a meaningful place in our interpretation of reality.

The idea that knowledge is intrinsically connected to the concept of love is found in the Old Testament. Pannenberg refers to the use of the term *emeth* (faith or trust) in the Old Testament and concludes that it operates historically in that it refers to 'the ever repeated reliability and faithfulness of persons in relationships, which is a fundamental moral concept of truth' (Buller 1996, 33). The Hebrew word *jadah* (to know) similarly points to a personal form of knowing such as sexual knowledge (Gen. 3·7, 4·1). It can also point to knowing that is based on experience, such as Pharaoh getting to 'know that I am Lord' (Exod. 7·17). Semantically, the word functions in the domain of *know very well*, *to be sure of something*, *to become aware*, *to understand*, *to acknowledge*, *to see*. In the New Testament the concept of truth is closely connected to the person of Christ.

> *In John alētheia* is the divine reality which is manifest in Jesus. Jesus' self identification with aletheia in 14:6 is central to the Johannine concept of truth... Whereas in 14:6 aletheia is what Jesus is, 16:13 speaks of all truth as what Jesus has. But both expressions practically mean the same thing, Jesus is what he has and brings (Thüsing, 1960, 146, 148).

Truth is thus not neutral. It functions in the domain of inter-personal relationships. Christ reveals himself as the One who loves those whom He invites to know and love him in return.

> The Spirit's role in the sending of the Son outward to creatures in life and ministry compels Christ to know, to be known, to love and be loved by those who are unlike. Therefore the dialectical principle of love describes the Son's relationship with creaturely existence, which in the synoptic gospels occurs in the Spirit (Harvie, 2009, 102).

To know Christ in truth is to know his love. Paul's prayer is for the Ephesian believers to know the fullness of the love of Christ (Eph. 3·14-19). True knowledge is thus to be loved. To know the truth is also a call to love in return. In 1 John knowing and loving God imply each other. To love another is to become open to be changed by who the other is. To know God is to be inwardly affected by his concerns, his plans, his will, his motivation, his character as the God who loves.

Justin Thacker (2007, 99ff.) suggests that the rationality of Christ is the root of our knowledge of God and love of the Other. He defines the rationality of Christ as a rationality that is embodied in a humble love and service of the Other. 'Moreover, precisely because Christ's rationality is one that supervenes upon all our thinking and modes of being, it is impossible for our knowledge of God and love of the Other to become separated' (2007, 3). He bases his thesis on three arguments: (a) that very claim to knowledge instantiates some ethical conception; (b) that it is impossible to know God apart from Christ and a *perichoretic* participation with him and, thus, (c) that it is impossible to know God in the absence of such an agapaeistic ethic in our lives.

The *perichoretic* participation with Christ is realized through the Spirit. The presence of the Spirit creates community between believers and God, and also between believers amongst each other, by pointing to their reconciliation to God and each other in Christ Jesus. Truth in love can only function as a community event. Knowledge consists of a shared interpretation of what 'is', that draws on the experiences of many people from many contexts. The seeking after truth in love is always aimed at continuing the conversation between those with different interpretations in order to work towards reconciliation and a shared interpretation of reality. Truth does not function outside of and apart from the views of other believers. The Spirit has taken up residence within humanity through faith and confronts us through a human face both in those who support us and those who, at times, may disagree with us and stand against us.

Love as a means of knowing requires action and involvement from the one who studies. To know in love is to act. According to Heschel (1965, 107) the Old Testament view of humanity differs from the Greek perspective. Where the latter is focused on what is the essence of being human, the Old Testament asks instead what is required from being human? Whereas Heschel, as a Jewish scholar, defines human existence as 'I am commanded—therefore I am' (1965, 111), the New Testament adds the perspective 'I am loved therefore I am'. The requirement to love is, and remains, an invitation to love in response to being loved by God. Without love all our other actions, even religious actions, count for nothing (1 Cor. 13:2). Knowledge as a way of acting in love towards others calls for the ability to listen, empathize, discern; to engage all our senses in learning so that we are able to serve the other better in love. An epistemology grounded in love, therefore, does not objectify the Other but recognizes him or her as a unique subject that surpasses

the possibility of ever knowing them in full. Knowledge as love, at its core, is critical of objectivity and neutrality as a way of distancing the knower from the known; it is biased towards the person and well-being of the other.

Love individualizes; it does not allow the specific and individual to be subsumed under general categories; the general and universal are always tested and modified in terms of their impact on the individual subject within the here and now. Love-based knowledge engages with the other within the lived-through reality of his or her existence. The context of the other is evaluated in terms of its impact on the life of those who are known; true knowledge fosters life and growth. Where the context binds or degrades the other, love seeks to learn in order to intervene, transform and liberate.

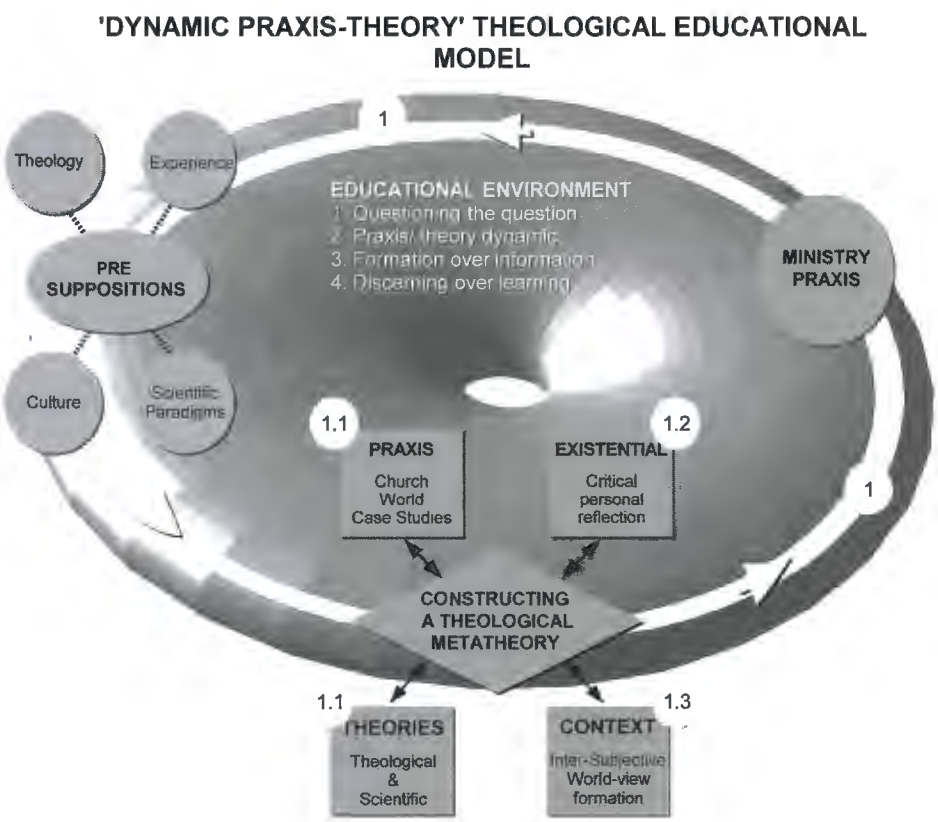
Non-Foundational Theological Educational Process

Theological education founded on a theological epistemology of faith, hope and love is primarily about engendering a new way of thinking within a theological educational environment marked by the epistemological characteristics described above. In this way students are empowered to construct a critical theological interpretive framework within which to analyse and meaningfully recreate reality. At its deepest level it exposes and challenges the unacknowledged meta-theoretical presuppositions that inform the students' interpretation of, and engagement with, the world.[11] It, thus, requires students to critically reflect on their thinking. 'Metatheorizing is fundamentally a consciousness-raising exercise' (Edwards, 2008, 3·65). Because theology deals with deep-seated, intimate and final experiences, theological challenges on a meta-theoretical level may often be experienced as uncomfortable and disruptive. 'If "we are what we know", if our sense of self is based in part on our body of knowledge of the world, then to change that body of knowledge may be threatening to our sense of self' (Fisher, 2005, 3). To help students overcome their sense of disorientation, it is important that they must first be theologically grounded in the epistemology employed in theological education.

A Dynamic Praxis-Theory Theological Educational Model

In the *Dynamic Praxis-Theory Educational Model* critical meta-theoretical analysis and construction takes place as an interplay between (a) the praxis (both in the church and the world), (b) theories (theological, scientific and naïve theories), (c) the context (inter-subjective, cultural and ideological interpretations of reality within which, and according to which, students are prone to think), and (d) students' personal existential engagement with, and interpretation of, reality. Through a theological epistemology characterized by faith, hope and love, students are enabled to construct new interpretations of reality and expose and

[11] A distinction needs to be made between general meta-theories and domain-specific meta-theories. The general meta-theory supplies the general precepts about being and cannot be applied directly to research (Cruickshank, 2003, 143).



deconstruct the meta-theories informing their current thinking and thus challenge any non-theological approaches to the formation of truth.

Theological education is designed to encourage students to critically consider their mode of thinking and equip them to develop alternative interpretations to a number of key issues in their personal life, the church and the world in terms of a theologically grounded epistemology by (what the model indicates as) *constructing a theological meta-theory*. Each subject across the theological field can encourage students to reflect a theologically grounded epistemology by exposing, challenging and reconstructing the way students think about, and respond to, broken reality in the light of the theological truth claims of the gospel.

Deconstruction of the assumptions that students bring to any interpretation of what 'is' takes place through critical exposure of students to the tension between ideal theological, as well as other scientific, theories, and the underlying operational theories of the praxis (indicated in the model through the two domains of *Ministry praxis* and *Theory*). The underlying theories of the praxis may not always be consciously held ('blind praxis') and can only be exposed by analysing the history, motivations, goals and perceived meaning of the actions by those doing them, and evaluating them against ideal theological theories for such actions. Students are equipped to expose theories and assumptions which people hold as abstract or background beliefs but which do not directly inform their

praxis ('blind theories'). By 'questioning the question' theological, cultural and ideological presuppositions may be exposed and evaluated in the light of the epistemological criteria for theological truth. For example: students who study evangelism should not only question their theories in terms of the praxis (to determine if it really works) or the praxis in the light of the theory (does it align to a biblical model of evangelism) but should also question how the theory and practices reflect the theological epistemological characteristics of faith, hope and love.

The section entitled *Ministry praxis* within the model indicates the need for students to be exposed to the lived-through reality which militates against the presuppositions of their theological theories. The *Ministry praxis* is essential for theological education to operate with an epistemology characterized by faith, hope and love. Engagement with the praxis means becoming vulnerable within, and to, the *lived through reality* and exposes students to the possibility of alternative interpretations of reality which may challenge their theological theories as interpretations of reality. Such exposure to alternative, resistant interpretations of reality may result in the construction of new assumptions about reality, indicated in the model by *Presuppositions*, which again need to be exposed, deconstructed and transformed on a theological, meta-theoretical level.

To construct a *Theological meta-theory* requires (a) critical reflection on the dynamic tension between *Theory* and *Praxis* as generated by an engagement with the world in faith, hope and love; (b) the personal reflection on, and transformation of, the learners' intentional relationship to that which 'is' and that which 'ought to be' in the light of faith, hope and love (*Existential*); and (c) a critical analysis of the presuppositions informing the lived-through reality which forms the context within which theological knowledge must operate. The students' epistemological reinterpretation of reality, and practical actions to create meaning within this reality, while remaining vulnerable to resistance and non-compliance from the same reality, requires meta-theoretical theological transformation. It is only as students remain intentionally directed in faith, hope and love to the transformation of this broken reality in the light of the alternative truth claims of the gospel that they can be said to be educationally engaged with theology.

The epistemological characteristics of theology are predominantly transferred to the students through the way in which theological lecturers embody them in both their class teaching and their commitment to God's cause outside the classroom. Theological knowledge must be demonstrated as a way of thinking and a way of actively being in the world in the service of God and for the benefit of others. Theological teaching should thus take place in the context of struggle, failure, victory, praise and gratitude; the lifeblood of worship.

Conclusion

Theological education not only deals with God as its unique object, but it also has to utilize a unique theological epistemology to equip students to seek after, create, and act according to, a theologically grounded epistemology. In this article I have shown that faith, hope and love form the key dimensions of such a theological epistemology. These three combine to free theological epistemology from certainty

and triumphalism without lapsing into fideism and relativism. All three modes of knowing are grounded upon, and intersect with each other, in the person of Christ who is the final truth of all theology. Faith, it has been shown, supports a critical realist approach to reality that is marked by an openness to doubt. In order to overcome such doubt, faith is built on the narratives of God's overcoming transformation of reality to reflect his re-creation of broken reality in Christ. Hope, it has been argued, sets truth in the context of a future expectation for the return of Christ with the implication that all truth is seen as provisional and revisable in the light of what 'will be'. The dimension of love has been found to bind truth to the Other through acts of service and liberation. God, it has been argued, is revealed through the Spirit in the Other. Theological truth based on love has been shown to be relational, personal and communal and transformational.

Theological education needs to reflect the three-fold trajectory of theological epistemology as a way of thinking and a way of being in the world. This can only happen through an engagement with the praxis and the deconstruction of the presuppositions that students have about reality, knowledge and values. Such deconstruction of presuppositions and the construction of new presuppositions take place through meta-theoretical theological reflection. Meta-theoretical reflection takes place within the context of the tension between theory and praxis;[12] the student's personal existential engagement with reality in faith, hope and love; and a critical analysis of the presuppositions informing the context in which the theological knowledge is brought to bear. Theological education is not completed unless students test it through ministry praxis marked by faith, hope and love.

References

Balthasar, H. U. von, 2005. *Theo-logic: The Spirit of Truth*. San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press.

Berkhof, H., and S. Woudstra. 2002. *Christian Faith: An Introduction to the Study of the Faith*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans.

Bernstein, R. J. 2011. *Praxis and Action: Contemporary Philosophies of Human Activity*. Pennsylvania: University of Pennsylvania Press.

Buber, M. 1988. *Eclipse of God: Studies in the Relation between Religion and Philosophy*. Amherst, NY: Humanities Press International.

Buller, C. A. 1996. *The Unity of Nature and History in Pannenberg's Theology*. London: Rowman & Littlefield.

Cruickshank, J. 2003. *Realism and Sociology: Anti-foundationalism, Ontology, and Social Research*. London and New York: Routledge.

Dale, J. 2005. 'Reflective Judgment: Seminarians Epistemology in a World of Relativism'. *Journal of Psychology and Theology* 33.1: 1–2.

Edwards, M. 'Evaluating Integral Metatheory: An Exemplar Case and a Defense of Wilber's Social Quadrant'. *Journal of Integral Theory and Practice* 3.4: 65.

[12] The term *praxis* is used in this article in line with Pieterse's definition (Pieterse, 1993, 173) as 'gereflekteerde praktyk' (practices under reflection, translation Andre van Oudtshoorn (AvO)). Aristotle linked the concept of praxis to 'practical reasoning' or *phronesis*. For Aristotle this knowledge is contextual, moral and linked to transformational actions (Bernstein, 2011, XIII). This thought was further developed by Marx (1994, 99-101 Thesis 2,7,11), Gadamer (2004), Habermas (see Pieterse, 1993, 87) and Bernstein (Bernstein, 2011) amongst others. In this article, the contextual transformational actions operate in the service of the gospel.

Erickson, M. J. 1998. *Christian Theology.* Grands Rapids, MI: Baker Academic.
Fisher, K. E. 2005. *Theories of Information Behavior.* Medford, NJ: Information Today, Inc.
Gadamer, H. G. 2004. *Truth and Method.* London: Continuum International.
Geertz, C. 1973. *The Interpretation of Cultures: Selected Essays.* New York, NY: Basic Books.
Harvie, T. 2009. *Jürgen Moltmann's Ethics of Hope: Eschatological Possibilities for Moral Action.* Surrey, UK: Ashgate.
Hegel, G. W. F. 2010. *The Philosophy of History.* Rockville, MD: Wildside Press LLC.
Heschel, A. J. 1965. *Who is Man?* Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press.
Hofer, B. K. 2004. *Personal Epistemology: Paradigmatic Approaches to Understanding Students' Beliefs about Knowledge and Knowing.* London: Routledge.
van Huyssteen, W. 1997. *Essays in Postfoundationalist Theology.* Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans.
Kirk, J. A., and K. J. Vanhoozer. 1999. *To Stake a Claim: Mission and the Western Crisis of Knowledge.* MaryKnoll, NY: Orbis Books.
——1969. *Nieuwe inleiding tot de existentiële fenomenologie.* Utrecht: Het Spectrum.
Martin, M. 1992. *Atheism: A Philosophical Justification.* Philadelphia, PA: Temple University Press.
Marx, K. 1994. *Selected Writings.* Cambridge, MA: Hackett.
Moltmann, J. 2001. *The Crucified God.* Hymns Ancient & Modern Ltd.
Niebuhr, H. R., with J. M. Gustafson and W. Schweiker. 1999. *The Responsible Self: An Essay in Christian Moral Philosophy.* Westminster John Knox Press.
Norris, C. 2006. *On Truth and Meaning: Language, Logic and the Grounds of Belief.* London: Continuum International.
——1976. *Theology and the Philosophy of Science.* London: Darton, Longman & Todd.
Pieterse, H. J. C. 1993. *Praktiese Teologie as Kommunikatiewe Handelingsteorie.* Human Sciences Research Council.
Putnam, H. 1979. *Mind, Language, and Reality.* Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
Quine, W. V. O., and J. S. Ullian. 1978. *The Web of Belief.* Random House.
Schaff, P. 2007. *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers: First Series, Volume V St. Augustine: Anti-Pelagian Writings.* Cosimo, Inc.
Smith, D. W., and McIntyre, R. 1982. *Husserl and Intentionality: A Study of Mind, Meaning, and Language.* New York: Springer.
Thacker, J. 2007. *Postmodern and the Ethics of Theological Knowledge.* Ashgate.
Theissen, G. 1979. *A Critical Faith: A Case for Religion.* Fortress Press.
Thüsing, W. 1960. *Die Erhöhung und Verherrlichung Jesu im Johannesevangelium*, Münster Westfalen: Aschendorff.
Zagzebski, L. 2009. *On Epistemology.* Wadsworth Philosophical Topics. Melbourne: Cengage Learning.

Notes on contributor

Correspondence to: André van Oudtshoorn, andre@pbc.wa.edu.au

Copyright of Journal of Adult Theological Education is the property of Maney Publishing and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.